Topic 9 — Indian Festivals & Fairs

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Festivals of India | State-wise Festivals | Folk Festivals | Tribal Festivals | North-East Indian Festivals | South Indian Festivals | Religious Festivals | Fairs of India | Cultural Festivals Organized by Government

Sources: Ministry of Culture / Tourism, UNESCO ICH, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs

- **Maha Kumbh** at Prayagraj ran from **13 January to 26 February 2025**, about **45** days.
- **Pushkar Kumbh** of **May 2025** was at Mana / Keshav Prayag in **Uttarakhand** (उत्तराखंड). It is not the Rajasthan camel fair.
- **Garba** (गरबा) of Gujarat entered UNESCO ICH in **December 2023**.
- **Durga Puja of Kolkata** entered UNESCO ICH in **2021**.
- **Kumbh Mela** (कुंभ मेला) entered UNESCO ICH in **2017**.
- The **SCO Film Festival** was held at Mumbai in **January 2023**.

---.

9.1 Festivals of India

A festival is a recurring community celebration. It may mark season, harvest, faith, or nation. Learn the type and the state.

- Three calendars run together: Gregorian, Hindu lunar (Chaitra–Phalgun) and regional solar (Pongal, Bihu, Onam).
- Harvest festivals include Pongal, Onam, Bihu, Makar Sankranti and Baisakhi.
- Religious festivals include Diwali, Eid, Christmas, Buddha Purnima and Mahavir Jayanti.
- Folk and regional festivals include Braj Holi, Garba and Lohri.
- Tribal festivals include Sarhul, Hornbill and Bastar Dussehra.
- National festivals are Republic Day on **26 January**, Independence Day on **15 August** and Gandhi Jayanti on **2 October**.
- The pan-India Hindu spine includes Diwali, Holi, Navratri, Dussehra, Janmashtami, Mahashivratri and Raksha Bandhan.
- Festival-named UNESCO ICH entries are **Ramlila 2008**, **Kumbh Mela 2017**, **Durga Puja of Kolkata 2021** and **Garba of Gujarat 2023**.
- Nawruz / Navroz is also UNESCO (multinational). It is the Parsi New Year in India.

- Not every colourful festival is Hindu. Bihu, Onam and Hornbill have regional or tribal roots.

> **Logic:** First fact **type**, then **state**. Stops “Holi = north only” and “Onam = Tamil Nadu.”

9.2 State-wise Festivals

Learn one flagship festival per state. Wrong-pair questions often swap neighbouring states.

- **Andhra Pradesh**: Celebrates **Ugadi** (the Telugu New Year) as its premier state festival.
- **Arunachal Pradesh**: Marks the Buddhist New Year with **Losar** and the Theravada Buddhist water festival **Sangken** (community New Year among Tai groups such as Khamti). Celebrated tribal festivals include **Solung** and **Mopin** (both **Adi** agricultural festivals) and **Nyokum** (Nyishi tribe).
- **Assam**: Anchors its cultural calendar around the three **Bihu** harvest festivals (Rongali, Kongali, Bhogali); the sacred **Ambubachi Mela** is observed annually at the Kamakhya Temple in Guwahati.
- **Bihar**: Celebrates **Chhath Puja** (dedicated to the Sun God) as its paramount cultural festival and hosts the historic **Sonepur Cattle Fair** (Asia's largest animal fair at Harihar Kshetra).
- **Chhattisgarh**: Renowned for the unique 75-day-long **Bastar Dussehra**, honoring the local patron deity Goddess Danteshwari.
- **Goa**: Celebrates the vibrant pre-Lenten **Goa Carnival** and the joyous spring festival of **Shigmo** (the Goan counterpart of Holi).
- **Gujarat**: Celebrates nine nights of **Navratri** (नवरात्रि) with community **Garba** and Dandiya Raas (inscribed on UNESCO ICH in 2023), alongside **Uttarayan** (the International Kite Festival on Makar Sankranti).
- **Haryana**: Hosts the globally acclaimed **Surajkund International Crafts Mela** annually in February at Faridabad.
- **Himachal Pradesh**: Renowned for the week-long **Kullu Dussehra**, commencing on Vijayadashami day in the Dhalpur ground of Kullu.
- **Jharkhand**: Celebrates **Sarhul** (the tribal festival of the Sal tree blossoms), alongside **Karma Puja** and extensive observances of **Chhath Puja** across the plateau.
- **Karnataka**: Celebrates the grand ten-day **Mysore Dasara** (featuring the Jamboo Savari elephant procession), alongside **Ugadi** (Kannada New Year) and the **Hampi Utsav**.
- **Kerala**: Celebrates **Onam** as its signature harvest festival (commemorating King Mahabali), alongside the vibrant elephant and percussion spectacle **Thrissur Pooram** and the astronomical New Year **Vishu**.
- **Madhya Pradesh**: Hosts the premier classical **Khajuraho Dance Festival**, the prestigious **Tansen Samaroh** (classical music festival in Gwalior), and the vibrant tribal **Bhagoria** festival among the Bhils.
- **Maharashtra**: Celebrates **Ganesh Chaturthi** as its most prominent socio-religious festival, alongside **Gudi Padwa** (गुड़ी पड़वा) (the Marathi New Year).
- **Manipur**: Highlights the **Sangai Festival** (named after the state's endangered brow-antlered deer), alongside the spring festival of **Yaoshang** (the Meitei celebration akin to Holi).

- **Meghalaya**: Renowned for **Wangala** (the 'Hundred Drums' post-harvest festival of the Garo tribe) and the religious thanksgiving dance-festival **Nongkrem** among the Khasi people.
- **Mizoram**: Celebrates **Chapchar Kut**, the major agricultural spring festival celebrated with the Cheraw bamboo dance after clearing the jhum fields.
- **Nagaland**: Hosts the famed **Hornbill Festival** (the 'Festival of Festivals') at the Kisama Heritage Village near Kohima, held annually from 1–10 December.
- **Odisha**: Renowned for the massive annual **Ratha Yatra** of Lord Jagannath at Puri, the agricultural harvest festival **Nuakhai**, and the classical **Konark Dance Festival**.
- **Punjab**: Celebrates **Baisakhi** (marking the harvest and the founding of the Khalsa in 1699) and the winter bonfire harvest festival **Lohri**.
- **Rajasthan**: Hosts the world-renowned **Pushkar Fair** (the camel and livestock fair held in the Hindu month of Kartik near Ajmer), alongside **Teej**, **Gangaur**, and the **Desert Festival** in Jaisalmer.
- **Sikkim**: Celebrates the Tibetan Buddhist New Year **Losar** and the sacred tripartite Buddhist festival of **Saga Dawa**.
- **Tamil Nadu**: Celebrates **Pongal** (the four-day harvest festival in January), the festival of lights **Karthigai Deepam** (famed at Tiruvannamalai), and the Tamil New Year **Puthandu**.
- **Telangana**: Celebrates the unique floral festival of **Bathukamma**, the mother-goddess festival of **Bonalu**, and the monumental biennial tribal gathering **Medaram Jatara** (Sammakka Saralamma Jatara).
- **Tripura**: Celebrates **Kharchi Puja** (the worship of the fourteen deities at Old Agartala) and the post-harvest tribal dance-festival **Garia Puja**.
- **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश): Anchored by the mega **Kumbh / Magh Mela** at Prayagraj, the world-famous **Braj Holi** (Mathura, Vrindavan, Barsana), the traditional **Ramlila** (notably at Ramnagar, Varanasi), and the **Taj Mahotsav** in Agra.
- **Uttarakhand**: Renowned for the **Haridwar Kumbh Mela** on the Ganga; additionally hosted the special **Pushkar Kumbh** at Mana / Keshav Prayag in May 2025.
- **West Bengal**: Renowned for **Durga Puja** (दुर्गा पूजा) (inscribed on UNESCO ICH in 2021) and the massive pilgrimage bath at **Gangasagar Mela** on Makar Sankranti.
- **Delhi (UT)**: Hosts the **Qutub Festival** of music and dance, and the historic interfaith communal harmony festival **Phool Walon Ki Sair** in Mehrauli.
- **Ladakh (UT)**: Marks the Tibetan New Year **Losar** and hosts the monastic masked-dance festival at the **Hemis Gompa**.
- **Jammu & Kashmir (UT)**: Renowned for the spring **Tulip Festival** at the Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden in Srinagar and historic Sufi **Urs** fairs across the valley.
- **Puducherry (UT)**: Commemorates Franco-Indian cultural links with **Bastille Day** celebrations alongside traditional Tamil **Pongal** festivities.

> **Logic:** Onam = Kerala. Pongal = Tamil Nadu. Hornbill = Nagaland. Pushkar Fair = Rajasthan. Pushkar Kumbh 2025 = Uttarakhand**.

9.3 Folk Festivals

Folk festivals are village and regional celebrations of dance, song, and season. They are not Sangeet Natak Akademi classical forms.

- **Braj Holi** is centered in Mathura, Vrindavan, Barsana, and Nandgaon in **UP**, celebrated around Krishna-Radha traditions and attracting national and international visitors.
- **Lathmar Holi** (लाठमार होली) is of Barsana–Nandgaon in **Uttar Pradesh. Women beat men with sticks in play.
- **Phoolon ki Holi** is the flower Holi at Banke Bihari, Vrindavan.
- **Garba / Dandiya** is of Gujarat. It is Navratri circles and UNESCO **2023**. It is not Rajasthan.
- **Bhangra / Giddha** is of Punjab. It is the Baisakhi harvest.
- **Lohri** is of Punjab / Haryana / Himachal. It is a January bonfire.
- **Teej** is of Rajasthan, UP and Haryana. It is monsoon swings and women-centred.
- **Gangaur** is of Rajasthan. It is Gauri worship in spring.
- **Uttarayan** is Gujarat's kite festival on Makar Sankranti.
- **Pulikali** is Kerala's tiger-dance in the Onam season.
- The **Theyyam** (तेय्यम) season is north Kerala ritual folk worship.
- The mid-January harvest belt is Lohri, then Makar Sankranti, then Pongal.

> **Logic:** Braj Holi = UP. Garba = Gujarat**. Folk dance at a festival is not a ninth SNA classical.

9.4 Tribal Festivals

Tribal festivals are Adivasi ritual. They centre on a sacred grove, a tree, or a clan deity. They are not the same as village Holi.

- **Sarhul** is of Jharkhand (Munda, Oraon). It is **sal tree** and earth worship in the Sarna tradition.
- **Karma** is of Jharkhand / Chhattisgarh. It is Karma-tree worship.
- **Bastar Dussehra** is of Chhattisgarh. It lasts about **75 days** and honours Devi **Danteshwari**. It is not Rama–Ravana.
- **Hornbill** covers all Naga tribes. It is a government showcase festival of Nagaland held in **Kohima** each December.
- **Medaram Jatara** is of Telangana. It is of the **Koya** tribe and Sammakka–Sarakka. It is biennial and among Asia's largest tribal gatherings.
- **Bhagoria Haat** is of Madhya Pradesh. It is a **Bhil** Holi-season tribal fair.
- **Wangala** is of Meghalaya. It is the **Garo** (गारो) Hundred Drums harvest thanks.
- **Nongkrem** is of Meghalaya. It is **Khasi** (खासी).
- **Chapchar Kut** is of Mizoram. It is a spring bamboo-clearing festival.
- **Lai Haraoba** is of Manipur. It is the Meitei indigenous creation festival and a pre-Vaishnava layer.
- **Tusu Parab** is the Jharkhand / West Bengal tribal harvest.
- **Nyokum** is of Arunachal. It is Nyishi.

- **Solung** is of Arunachal. It is the Adi agricultural festival.
- **Mopin** is also of Arunachal. It is an **Adi** agricultural festival meant to drive away evil spirits and seek prosperity. It is **not** a Garo festival (Garo harvest = **Wangala** in Meghalaya).
- **Sangken** is of Arunachal. It is a Buddhist New Year / water-sprinkling festival. Do not swap it with Losar alone.

> **Logic:** Sarhul = Jharkhand. Bastar Dussehra = Chhattisgarh**, 75 days, not standard Dussehra.

9.5 North-East Indian Festivals

North-East festivals cover the seven sister states and Sikkim. This belt has the highest tribal-festival density.

- **Bihu** is **Assam only**. It is not Arunachal and not Nagaland.
- The three Bihus are **Rongali / Bohag** (April, most festive), **Kongali / Kati** (autumn) and **Bhogali / Magh** (January harvest bonfire).
- **Hornbill Festival** is of **Nagaland**. It runs **1–10 December** at **Kisama** Heritage Village. It is branded "Festival of Festivals."
- **Sangai Festival** is of **Manipur**. It is in November and is named after the **Sangai deer** (state animal).
- **Yaoshang** is of Manipur. It is a five-day spring festival with a Holi colour.
- **Chapchar Kut** is of Mizoram. It falls in March.
- **Wangala** is of Meghalaya (Garo).
- **Losar** is the Tibetan Buddhist New Year. It is kept in **Sikkim, Arunachal, Ladakh and Himachal**. It is not NE-only.
- **Saga Dawa** is of Sikkim. It is the Buddha month.
- **Ambubachi Mela** is at **Kamakhya**, Guwahati, Assam. It is a June tantric annual fair.
- **Kharchi Puja** is of Tripura.
- **Ziro Festival of Music** is of Arunachal. It is a modern tourism overlay, not a tribal new-year.

> **Logic:** Bihu–Assam. Hornbill–Nagaland (Kisama, December). Sangai–Manipur**.

9.6 South Indian Festivals

South Indian festivals cover Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Puducherry. Harvest rites, temple cars, and royal Dasara sit here.

- **Pongal** is the Tamil Nadu harvest festival. It falls in mid-January and lasts four days.
- **Bhogi** is the first day. It is a bonfire of old things.
- **Thai Pongal** is rice boiled in a new pot. It is the name-day.
- **Mattu Pongal** is cattle worship.

- **Kaanum Pongal** is the outing / family visit.
- **Jallikattu** is bull-taming in the Pongal season in Tamil Nadu. It is not Kerala.
- **Puthandu** is the Tamil New Year (April).
- **Karthigai Deepam** is the grand festival of lights in Tamil Nadu, celebrated with immense devotion atop the holy hill of **Tiruvannamalai** (Annamalaiyar Temple).
- **Onam** is of **Kerala**. It lasts about 10 days in August–September and marks King **Mahabali**.
- Onam marks include the *pookalam* flower carpet, *Vallamkali* snake-boat and *Onasadya* feast.
- **Vishu** is Kerala's solar New Year. It falls in April with Vishukkani.
- **Thrissur Pooram** is of Kerala. It is a temple elephant caparison and is not Onam.
- **Mysore Dasara** is of Karnataka. It is a ten-day royal festival with the **Jamboo Savari** procession.
- **Hampi Utsav** is Karnataka's tourism festival at the Vijayanagara ruins.
- **Ugadi** is the Hindu New Year for **Andhra, Telangana and Karnataka**. It falls in March–April.
- **Gudi Padwa** is Maharashtra's New Year in the same season. It is not Ugadi's name.
- **Bathukamma** is of Telangana. Women stack seasonal flowers.
- **Bonalu** is of Telangana. It is a goddess offering.

> **Logic:** Pongal-TN | Onam-Kerala | Mysore Dasara-Karnataka**. Never swap the first two.

9.7 Religious Festivals

Religious festivals follow a faith calendar. They mark a deity, a prophet, or a sacred event. Many are gazetted holidays.

- **Diwali** (दिवाली) falls on Kartik Amavasya. It is Lakshmi–Ganesha, lights, and nationwide.
- **Holi** (होली) falls on Phalgun Purnima. It is colours, and Braj (UP) is the folk-famous form.
- **Navratri** is nine nights of the goddess in Ashwin. Gujarat's public face is Garba.
- **Dussehra / Vijayadashami** marks Rama's victory / goddess victory. The Ravana effigy is the northern form.
- **Durga Puja** is the Bengal pandal festival. UNESCO **2021** lists it as **Durga Puja of Kolkata**.
- **Janmashtami** (जन्माष्टमी) is Krishna's birth. Mathura–Vrindavan carries the weight.
- **Mahashivratri** is the Shiva night.
- **Chhath Puja** is **Surya** worship at river ghats. It belongs to **Bihar, eastern UP and Jharkhand**. It is not moon worship.
- **Ratha Yatra** is of **Puri, Odisha**. Jagannath, Balabhadra and Subhadra chariots run in June–July.
- **Ramlila** is Ramayana enactment. It is of **UP** (Ramnagar–Varanasi, Braj) and UNESCO **2008**.
- **Eid-ul-Fitr** marks the end of **Ramadan**.
- **Eid-ul-Adha** is Bakrid. It is the sacrifice.
- **Muharram** (मुहर्रम) is Ashura mourning. Lucknow is a major **Shia** centre in UP.
- **Christmas** falls on **25 December**.
- **Guru Nanak Jayanti** is Gurpurab.

- **Baisakhi** is when the Sikh **Khalsa** (खालसा) was founded in **1699**. It is also the Punjab harvest.
- **Buddha Purnima** (बुद्ध पूर्णिमा) (Vesak) falls on Vaishakha Purnima, commemorating the three holiest milestones in the life of Gautama Buddha: his birth, enlightenment (*Bodhi*), and mahaparinirvana.
- **Mahavir Jayanti** (महावीर जयंती) is Jain.
- **Paryushana** is the Jain fasting festival.
- **Navroz / Nowruz** is the Parsi New Year. UNESCO Nawruz is multinational.

> **Logic:** Chhath = Sun**, Bihar/east UP.** Ramlila = UNESCO 2008**, not a classical dance.

9.8 Fairs of India

A mela is a periodic socio-religious gathering. Trade, pilgrimage, and public spectacle meet there. **Kumbh Mela** is the premier mega-gathering.

- **Kumbh Mela** is UNESCO ICH **2017**. It is the largest peaceful pilgrimage gathering.
- The four sites only are **Prayagraj, Haridwar, Nashik and Ujjain**.
- **Prayagraj** is Triveni Sangam. It is Ganga, Yamuna and mythical Saraswati in **Uttar Pradesh**.
- **Haridwar** is on the Ganga in **Uttarakhand**.
- **Nashik** is on the Godavari in **Maharashtra**. The Trimbakeshwar link is named.
- **Ujjain** is on the Shipra in **Madhya Pradesh**. The Mahakaleshwar link is named.
- Each site hosts a Kumbh about every **12 years**. Across four sites a Kumbh falls roughly every **3–4 years**.
- **Ardh Kumbh** falls every **6 years** at Prayagraj and Haridwar.
- **Maha Kumbh** is held at Prayagraj every 144 years (following a cycle of 12 Purna Kumbhs); the historic **2025 Maha Kumbh** took place from **13 January to 26 February 2025**, spanning approximately 45 days at the Sangam.
- **Magh Mela** (माघ मेला) is the **annual** bathing fair at Prayagraj in Magh. It is not the full Kumbh.
- **Pushkar Fair** is at **Pushkar, Ajmer, Rajasthan**. It is camel and livestock in **Kartik** (Oct–Nov). It is not a 4-site Kumbh.
- **Pushkar Kumbh** is a different event. It is at **Keshav Prayag, Mana** (Chamoli) in **Uttarakhand**, at Alaknanda and Saraswati. It falls every **12 years** when Jupiter enters Gemini, and ran in **May 2025** (about 14–26 May).
- **Sonepur Mela** is of Bihar at Harihar Kshetra. It is Asia's large cattle fair in Kartik.
- **Surajkund International Crafts Mela** is at Faridabad in **Haryana**. It is a February government crafts fair.
- **Gangasagar Mela** is at Sagar Island, West Bengal. It is a Makar Sankranti bath.
- **Ambubachi Mela** is at Kamakhya, Assam. It falls in June.
- **Deva Mela** is at Barabanki in **Uttar Pradesh.
- **Bateshwar Fair** is in Agra district, **Uttar Pradesh. It is a livestock fair.
- **Nagaur Fair** is a Rajasthan cattle fair.

- **Kolayat Fair** (Kapil Muni Fair) is held in Bikaner, Rajasthan, centered around the sacred lake and ashram dedicated to sage Kapil Muni.

> **Logic:** The **May 2025 Pushkar Kumbh** was in **Uttarakhand only** — do not mark Rajasthan. Rajasthan owns the **Pushkar camel fair**, not this May Kumbh.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q97

In May 2025, Pushkar Kumbh Mela 2025 was organized in which of the following States?

1. Rajasthan
2. Uttar Pradesh
3. Uttarakhand

A. 1 and 2 B. Only 3 C. 2 and 3 D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: B — Only 3. Held at **Keshav Prayag, Mana** (near Badrinath), **Uttarakhand**. Pushkar town in Rajasthan is a different fair (Kartik camel mela). Not UP.

9.9 Cultural Festivals Organized by Government

Government cultural festivals are sponsored by the State or the Union for arts, crafts, and tourism. They are not a spontaneous village rite.

- **Surajkund International Crafts Mela** is of Haryana Tourism with Culture support. It is in **February** at Faridabad, not Delhi and not Rajasthan.
- **Khajuraho Dance Festival** is of MP. It is in February against the Chandela temples.
- **Konark Dance Festival** is of Odisha. It is in December on the Konark Sun Temple lawn.
- **Tansen Samaroh** is at **Gwalior, MP**. It is in December and is not UP.
- **Bharat Rang Mahotsav** is of the **National School of Drama**, New Delhi. It is January theatre, not SNA dance.
- **Hornbill Festival** is of the Nagaland government. It is at Kisama from 1–10 December.
- **Sangai Festival** is of the Manipur government. It is in November.
- **Taj Mahotsav** is at **Agra, Uttar Pradesh. It runs about** 10 days **in** February** under UP Tourism.
- **Ganga Mahotsav** is at **Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh. It is in November.
- **Lucknow Mahotsav** is at Lucknow. It is in November–December.
- **Ayodhya Deepotsav** is at Ayodhya. It is Diwali-season government lighting.
- **Hampi Utsav** is of Karnataka.
- **Qutub Festival** is of Delhi.
- **Rajgir Mahotsav** is of Bihar.
- **Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat** began in **2015**. It is a Ministry of Culture state-pair cultural exchange, not a single-city mela.

- **Kala Utsav** is school arts under the Ministry of Education.
- **Saras Aajeevika Mela** is of the Ministry of **Rural Development** / DAY-NRLM. It is rural SHG crafts. The **2021** edition was at **Noida Haat**.
- **SCO Film Festival 2023** was of the Ministry of I&B and NFDC. It ran at **Mumbai** from **27–31 January 2023** during India's SCO Presidency. It showcased films of SCO members.

> **Logic:** Surajkund = Haryana. Taj Mahotsav = Agra. Tansen = Gwalior (MP). Saras 2021 = Noida**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q39

The 'Saras Ajeevika Mela - 2021' was organised in which of the following city?

A. Patna B. Raipur C. Lucknow D. Noida

Show answer

Ans: D — Noida. Noida Haat. Rural Development / NRLM SHG crafts fair. Not Lucknow.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q87

With reference to the **SCO Film Festival–2023**, which of the following statement(s) is/are correct?

1. The SCO Film Festival is being held during India's Presidency of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation.
2. The SCO Film Festival showcases films from SCO member countries.

A. Only 1 B. Only 2 C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Show answer

Ans: C — Both 1 and 2. Mumbai, Jan 2023. I&B / NFDC. India's SCO Presidency.
